



INTRODUCTION

CHALLENGES OF CHANGE

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We meet here not in the best of times. In fact, it is the worst of times. The world economy is in a dizzying tailspin, the highest temples of capitalism are collapsing, everyone seems to be drowning in a sea of debt and there is a pall of gloom as we hurtle towards an uncertain future. Besides the economic slowdown, India is psychologically reeling from the horror of the attacks in Mumbai. Our neighbourhood is troubled too. At home, we are faced with a general election in the next 40 days. None of the parties including the national ones have a vision or message. The final result is likely to be a *khichdi* whose ingredients are still open to guesswork.

The good news is that you are in the right place at the right time. Welcome to the 8th India Today Conclave. And for the next two days, you should think, listen, question and argue with some of the finest minds in the world about what the future holds for us. This is where inventive minds breach the barriers of knowledge and a profusion of questions shatters the coziness of received wisdom. The Conclave is a festival of arguments. Arguments that make sense of the present whirl and seek patterns of the future. It is a celebration of our democracy. It is the tributary of a tradition, kept alive by INDIA TODAY magazine.

This year's theme is a logical progression from the last year's—Leadership for the 21st Century. Leadership means change. Naturally and quite aptly, our theme is: Challenges of Change. Inevitably, crisis brings in its wake change. And there is little doubt that we are in a crisis of epic proportions. With the great changes happening in the world today or likely to happen, the theme could not be more relevant. Not long ago, it seemed that our world

